

Jacana jacana

Wattled jacana



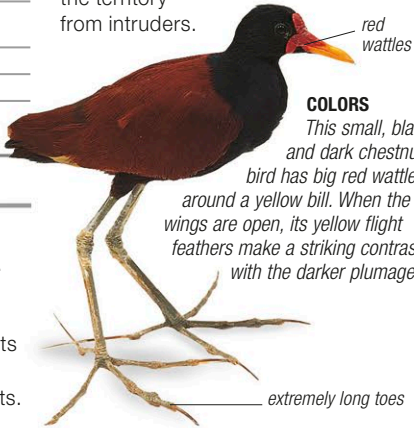
Location S. Central America, South America

Length 6½–10 in (17–25 cm)
Weight 3¼–5¼ oz (90–150 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



The 8 species of jacanas are notable for their long legs and very large feet. They also have a distinctive spur on the leading edge of each wing. The wattled jacana feeds mostly on insects and other aquatic invertebrates, but sometimes eats seeds from rice plants.

The female, much larger than the male and weighing about 5¼ oz (150 g), mates with up to 3 males. Each male builds a nest, incubates a clutch of eggs, and rears the young. The female defends the territory from intruders.

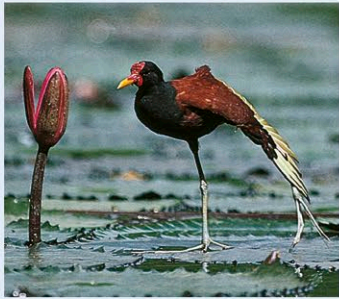


COLORS

This small, black and dark chestnut bird has big red wattles around a yellow bill. When the wings are open, its yellow flight feathers make a striking contrast with the darker plumage.

extremely long toes

WALKING ON WATER



As with the other species of jacanas, the wattled jacana has extraordinarily long toes that spread its weight as it walks, enabling it to move easily over the leaves of floating waterplants. Because of this behavior, jacanas are also called lily-trotters.

Dromas ardeola

Crab plover



Location E. Africa, S.W., S., and S.E. Asia

Length 15–16 in (38–41 cm)
Weight 8–12 oz (225–325 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



This thickset, black and white wader has an exceptionally large, powerful black bill, which it uses to crush the shells of crabs before swallowing them whole. The crab plover is also unusual among waders in that it digs a long burrow, in which it lays a single egg.

Rostratula benghalensis

Greater painted-snipe



Location Africa, S., E., and S.E. Asia

Length 9–11 in (23–28 cm)
Weight 3¼–7 oz (90–200 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



A medium-sized wader of freshwater marshes, the greater painted-snipe has a distinctive broad, white patch around each eye. It spends much of its time in deep cover, emerging—very



cautiously and mainly at night—to probe the mud for food. The greater painted-snipe has a rather weak, fluttering flight, with legs dangling. The male usually incubates the eggs and rears the young, while the female goes off to find another mate.

Haematopus ostralegus

Eurasian oystercatcher



Location Europe, N.W., N., and E. Africa, S.W., C., E., and S. Asia

Length 16–19 in (40–48 cm)
Weight 14–29 oz (400–800 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Near threatened



A widespread coastal and freshwater wader, the Eurasian oystercatcher is recognizable by its noisy calls and



bright orange bill. It feeds mainly on mussels, limpets, and cockles—either by cutting the muscle that holds the 2 halves of the shell together and stabbing the prey inside, or by hammering the shell open on rocks or hard sand.

Ibidorhyncha struthersii

Ibisbill



Location C. and E. Asia

Length 15–16 in (38–41 cm)
Weight 10–12 oz (275–325 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



A unique wader with a long, thin, downcurved red bill, the ibisbill is gray-brown above, and has a bluish gray breast, neck, and head, with a black face, and red legs. In spite of its striking coloration, the bird blends remarkably well with stony river banks. It feeds in mountain rivers, raking through the surface and probing under stones to find prey.



Himantopus himantopus

Black-winged stilt



Location Europe, Asia, Africa, North, Central, and South America

Length 14–16 in (35–40 cm)
Weight 5–7 oz (150–200 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



In relation to its body size, this wader has the longest legs of any bird, which enables it to feed in deeper water than most other waders. The black-winged stilt hunts by sight or touch, scything its fine, straight bill through the water to detect prey. This bird also chases insects on and above water, often twisting and leaping to catch them.

Recurvirostra avosetta

Pied avocet



Location Europe, Asia, Africa

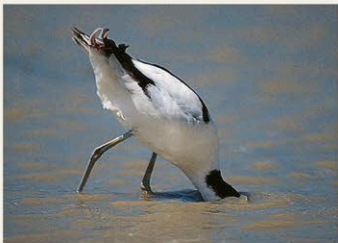
Length 16½–18 in (42–45 cm)
Weight 8–14 oz (225–400 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



slender, upcurved bill

Breeding in a band from Western Europe across Asia to China, this bird is the most widespread of the world's 4 species of avocets. In winter, it can be found in large flocks, mostly on the coast, in estuaries, and in nearby wetlands. It frequently roosts floating or swimming on water, and groups of birds can form large "rafts," looking from a distance rather like gulls. During the breeding season, it tends to move inland, to slightly brackish or saline marshes. The avocet defends its territory very aggressively, calling loudly if it senses danger and chasing off intruders.

FEEDING IN WATER



When feeding, the avocet sweeps its upcurved bill from side to side so that only the tip is immersed. However, if it sees something edible, it will lunge quickly forward, sometimes submerging its head as it pursues the prey.

black wing markings

UPTURNED BILL

The pied avocet is whiter than most other waders, with black markings on the head and wings, but its most distinctive feature is the long, slender, upcurved bill, the male's being longer and straighter than the female's.

